A Brief Moment in the Life of Angus Bethune

By Chris Crutcher

While farsighted parents of other infants my age were pre-enrolling their kids four years ahead into elite preschools, my dad was hounding the World Wrestling Federation to hold a spot for me sometime in the early 1990s. I mean, my mom had to go to the husky section of Safeway to buy me Pampers. I'm a big kid. And they named me Angus. God!

INTRODUCTION

According to the U.S. Department of Education, approximately 160,000 students a day stay home from school because they are afraid of being bullied. That's over 3 million a month. And the highest percentage of bullying is directed toward overweight students. Options: avoid the situation, or learn to take daily verbal and sometimes physical abuse. But if your name is Angus and you have two sets of gay parents . . . that's only the beginning. A Brief Moment in the Life of Angus Bethune by Chris Crutcher

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Sometimes, when I stand back and take a good look, I think my parents are ambassadors from hell. Two of them, at least, the biological ones, the *big* ones. Four parents are what I have altogether, not unlike a whole lot of other kids. But quite unlike a whole lot of other kids, there ain't a hetero among 'em. My dad's divorced and remarried, and my mom's divorced and remarried, so my mathematical account of my family suggests simply another confused teenager from a broken home. But my dads aren't married to my moms. They're married to *each other*. Same with my moms.

That frightening little off-season trade took place prior to – though not *much* prior to – my birth, so until I began collecting expert feedback from friends at school, somewhere along about fourth grade, I perceived my situation as relatively normal.

No, what really hacks me off is that when people the size of my parents decide to reproduce, they usually dig a pit and crawl down in there together for several days. Really, I'm surprised someone in this family doesn't

have a trunk. Or a blowhole. I swear my gestation period was three years and seven months.

"Angus is a cow," I said to my mother when she got home from her job at Westhead Trucking firm. "You guys named me after a cow."

"Your father's uncle was named Angus," she said.

"So my father's uncle was named after a cow, too," I said. "What did *he* think of that?"

"Actually," Mom said, "I think he was kind of proud. Angus was quite a farmer, you know."

"Jesus help me," I said, and went to my room.

As Angus, the fat kid with perverted parents, I've had my share of adjustment problems, though it isn't as bad as it sounds. I am *incredibly* quick for a fat kid, and I have world-class reflexes. Plus you don't have to dig *too* deep in our ancestral remains to find an IQ safely into three digits, so grades come pretty easy to me. But I'd sure be willing to go into the winter trade meetings and swap reflexes, biceps, and brain cells, lock, stock, and barrel, for a little physical beauty.

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Which brings me to tonight. Tonight is a big night, and I don't want the blubbery bogeyman or the phantoms of sexual perversity, who usually pop up to point me out for public mockery, mucking it up for me. I want *normal*. I want *socially acceptable*. See, I was elected Senior Winter Ball King, which means for about one minute I'll be featured gliding across the floor beneath the crimson and gold crepe paper streamers at lake Michigan High School with Melissa Lefevre, the girl of my dreams – and only my dreams – who was elected Senior Winter Ball Queen. For that minute we'll be out there alone. Alone with Melissa Lefevre.

I mean, it's a joke, I know that. I just don't know whose. It's a hell of a good one, though, because someone had to coax a plurality of more than five hundred seniors to forgo casting their ballots for any of a number of bona fide Adonises to write in the name of a cow. At first I tried to turn it down, but Granddad let me know right quick I'd draw a lot more attention if I made a fuss than if I acted as if I were the logical choice – indeed, the only choice – and went right along.

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Granddad is the man who taught me to be a dignified fat kid. "Always remember these words, and live by 'em," he said after my third suspension from kindergarten for fighting. "*Screw 'em.* Anybody doesn't like the way you look, screw 'em."

And that's just what I've done. Sometimes I've screwed 'em by punching them in the nose, and sometimes by walking away. And sometimes by joining them – you know, laughing at myself. That's the one that works best. So you see, slowly but surely I'm getting all this under control. I don't mind that my detractors will wonder aloud tonight whether it is Melissa or I who is the Winter Ball Queen, a playful reference to my folks' quirky preferences, and I don't mind that I'll likely hear, "Why do they just swim up on the beach like that?" at least three times. What I mind is that during those few seconds when Melissa and I have the floor to ourselves, all those kids will be watching me *dance*. Now, I've chronicled the majority of my maladies here, but none remotely approaches my altogether bankrupt sense of rhythm. When it comes to clapping his hands or stomping

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his feet to the beat, Angus Bethune is completely, absolutely, and, most of all, irreversibly brain dead.

I've known about the dance for three weeks now. I even know the name of the song, though I don't recognize it, and I went out and spent hard-earned money on dance lessons. [But] I've been planning for Melissa Lefevre for a long time. I fell in love with her in kindergarten, when she dared a kid named Alex Immergluck to stick his tongue on a car bumper in minus-thirty-five-degree weather for calling her a "big, fat, snot-nosed deadbeat." Being a fat kid, I was interested in all the creative retaliatory methods I could get to store in the old computer for later use, and when I saw the patch of Alex's tongue stuck tight to the bumper as he screamed down the street, holding his bleeding mouth, I knew I was in the company of genius.

The bottom line, though, [is] I would never have the opportunity for any conversation with Melissa other than one in my head. Until tonight. Tonight I'll *have* to talk to her. If I don't, she'll have only my dancing by which to remember me, which is like Mrs. Fudd

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remembering Elmer for his hair. It'd be a damn shame. All I really want is my moment with her. All I want is my moment.

So now I stand at the door to the gym. Heads turn as I move through the door. I see Melissa on the dance floor with her boyfriend – a real jerk in my book, Rick Sanford – and my heart bursts against the walls of my chest, like in *Alien*. I order it back. A sophomore server leaves a glass of punch on the table, and I sip it slowly through the next song, after which the lead singer announces that the "royal couple" and their court are due behind the stage curtain in five minutes. Tributaries of perspiration join at my rib cage to form a raging torrent of sweat rushing toward my shoes as I silently hyperventilate, listening for my grandfather's voice, telling me to screw 'em, telling me once again I can do anything I want. I want my moment.

I want to run. What am I doing here? What was I thinking of? Suddenly I'd give up my moment in a heartbeat for the right to disappear. What a fool, even to think…

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They stand before me. [Rick and Melissa] Melissa smiles. She says, "Hi." I smile and nod, any words far, far from my throat. Melissa says, "Why don't we go on up?" and she takes my arm, leaving Rick's hanging limply at his side.

"Yeah," he says, "why don't you go on up? You right on up behind that curtain with my girl, snowball king."

Melissa drops my arm and grips his elbow. "Shut up," she whispers between her clenched teeth. "I'm warning you, Rick. Shut up."

Rick tears his arm away. "Enjoy yourself," he says to me, ignoring her. "Your campaign cost me a lot of money, probably close to two bucks a pound." He looks me up and down as couples at the nearest tables turn to stare. The heat of humiliation floods up through my collar, and I fear the worst will follow. I fear I'll cry.

Melissa takes my arm again and says, "Let's go." We move two steps toward the stage, and Rick says loud, "Got your rubber gloves, honey?"

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"What do you mean by that?" I ask quietly, knowing full well what he means by that.

"I wasn't talking to you, bigfoot," Rick says, looking past me to his girl. "I'm asking if my sweetie's got her rubber gloves."

Melissa says, "I hate you, Rick. I really do."

Rick ignores her. "Bigfoot comes from a high-risk home," he says. "Best wear your rubber gloves, honey, in case he has a cut."

In that instant I sweep his feet with mine, and he lands hard on the floor. He moves to get up, but I'm over him, crowding. When he tries to push himself up, I kick his hands out, following his next movements like a cow dog, mirroring him perfectly, trapping him there on the floor. No chaperone is in view, so it isn't totally out of hand yet. When he sees he can't rise, I kneel, sweat pouring off my forehead like rain. Softly, very softly, I say, "You may not like how my parents live. But they've been together since 1971 – monogamous as the day is long. That's a low-risk group, Rick. The only person at high risk right now is you."

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He looks into my eyes, and he knows I mean it, knows I'm past caring about my embarrassment. "Okay, man," he says, raising his hands in surrender. "Just having a little fun."

I'm apologizing to Melissa all the way up the backstage stairs, but she's not having any. "You should have stomped on his throat," she says, and I involuntarily visualize Alex Immergluck clutching at his bleeding mouth in the freezing cold next to the car bumper. "If you ever get another chance, I'll pay you money."

At the side door to the stage I say, "Speaking of embarrassment, there's something you need to know." She waits. "I can't dance."

Melissa smiles. She says. "We'll survive."

I say, "Yeah, well, I didn't say I can't dance *well*. I said I can't dance. Good people have been badly hurt trying to dance with me." We take our places. The darkness of the stage and the silence are excruciating. The curtains part as the trumpets blare. I gaze out into the spotlights, smiling like a giant. The introduction of last year's king and queen begins, and they move toward

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us from stage left and right to relinquish their crowns to us. It all would be unbelievably ridiculous even if they weren't crowning King Angus the Fat. Without moving her lips, Melissa says, "I picked a slow song. We don't have to move much. Dance close to me. When you feel me lean, you lean. Whatever you do, don't listen to the music. It'll just mess you up. Trust me. My brother's like you. Just follow."

A part of me stays to concentrate, but another part goes to heaven. In my wildest dreams I could never have imagined Melissa Lefevre being *nice* to me in my moment, would never have *dared* imagine holding her tight without feeling pushy and ugly and *way* out of line. Feeling greedy now, I want my moment to last.

"Angus? "Do you ever get tired of who you are?"

I pull back a second, but it's like Lois Lane releasing Superman's hand twenty thousand feet in the air. She falls. I pull close again. "Do you know who you're talking to?"

I feel her smile. "Yeah," she says, "I thought so. I know it's not the same, but it's not always so great

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looking the way I do, either. I pay, too." She's right. I think it's not the same.

"Want to know something about me?" she asks. "I'm bulimic. Do you know what that is?"

I smile. "I'm a fat kid with faggot parents who's been in therapy on and off for eighteen years," I say. "Yes, I know what that is. It means when you eat too much, you chuck it up so you don't turn out to look like me."

"Close enough for discussion purposes. Don't worry, I'm in therapy for it," she says, noticing my concern. "*A lot* of pretty girls are."

"Actually," I say, "I even tried it once, but when I stuck my finger down my throat, I was still hungry and I almost ate my arm."

Melissa laughs and holds me tighter. "You're the only person I've ever told except for the people in my therapy group; I just wanted you to know things aren't always as they appear. Would you do me a favor?"

"If it doesn't involve more than giving up my life," I say, feeling wonderful because Melissa isn't a goddess

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anymore and because that doesn't change a thing about the way I feel about her.

"Would you leave with me? I like how you stood up for your family. It must be hard. Defending them all the time, I mean."

"Compared to me, a boy named Sue had it made," I say.

The music ends; all dancers stop and clap politely. "I want to dance one more," Melissa says. "A fast one."

"I'll wait over by the table."

"No. I want to dance it with you."

"You don't understand," I say. "When I dance to the beat of rock and roll, decent folks across this great land quake in their boots."

She holds my hand tightly. "Listen. Do what you did when you wouldn't let Rick up. Don't listen to the music; just follow me the way you followed him."

I try to protest; but the band breaks into "Bad Moon Rising," and the dance floor erupts. I back away as she comes at me, mirroring her every move, top to bottom. A crowd gathers and I'm trapped inside a

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cheering circle, actually performing the unheard of: I'm Angus Bethune, Fat Man Extraordinaire, dancing in the limelight with Melissa Lefevre, stepping outside the oppressive prison of my body to fly to the beat of Credence Clearwater Revival.

When the drummer bangs the last beat, the circle erupts in celebration, and I take a long, low bow. Melissa is clapping wildly.

Rick yells at the door as I help Melissa into her coat. "You practiced with this tub of lard! You guys were getting together dancing. You set me up." He turns to me. "I ought to take you out, fat boy," he says, but his unimaginative description can't touch my glory.

I put up a finger and wag it side to side in front of his nose. "You know the difference between you and me, Sanford?"

He says, "There are a lot of differences between us, lardo. You couldn't count the differences between us."

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"That's probably true," I say, closing my fist under his nose. "But the one that matters right now is that I can make *you* ugly."

He stares silently at my fist.

I say, "Don't even think it. Next to dancing, that's my strong suit."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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